

aimed at curbing excessive play and maintaining transparency

- The Advertising Standards Council of India's efforts led to the signing of a Code of Ethics by key industry bodies in March. Besides responsible advertising, self-regulation extends to spending limits etc.

**WHAT'S PLANNED**

- The Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C) under the home ministry is preparing a report for a dedicated law to regulate online gaming, betting, gambling and lotteries, and curb offshore platforms; potential stricter penalties could include 3-year prison terms and heavy fines
- The government is also working on bringing online gaming platforms under anti-money laundering laws, requiring stricter KYC compliance, maintenance of transaction records and reporting of any kind of suspicious activity

platforms that dodge Indian laws, helped along by the jurisdictional maze. While online gaming is a digital industry, transcending geographical boundaries, gambling is a state subject under the Constitution. Most states exempt games of skill from gambling restrictions. While Goa permits licensed physical casinos (games of chance), states like Nagaland, Sikkim and Meghalaya have introduced licensing frameworks specifically for online gaming. This mismatch complicates enforcement, leaving grey areas for platforms to exploit.

When MeitY took charge of online gaming in 2022, IT minister Ashwini Vaishnaw had called for "a central law" to regulate the sector. The I4C under the MHA is now working in this direction. Government insiders claim that several 'giant' platforms are under the lens for flouting existing rules. Once a new law is passed, accountability could also extend to the celebrities and influencers who endorse such platforms.

## The Self-regulation Push

To its credit, the industry has begun some self-regulation. On March 10, key industry bodies—the Federation of Indian Fantasy Sports (FIFS), All India Gaming Federation (AIGF) and the E-Gaming Federation (EGF)—announced a 'Code of Ethics' (CoE), as a culmination of efforts initiated by the Advertising Standards Council of India (ASCI). The members of these bodies include popular platforms like Dream11, MyTeam11, Zupee, A23 and Junglee Games. The CoE is aimed at enforcing consistent standards of user safety across the industry through the implementation of responsible gaming and advertising policies. It also mandates annual third-party audits and comprehensive reporting mechanisms to ensure accountability and transparency.

Roland Landers, CEO of the AIGF, tells INDIA TODAY that one advantage of operating as a digital platform is the ability to monitor user behaviour. "If we detect patterns of excessive use, we can step in and take preventive action," he says, while also stressing that "self-awareness and restraint from users are equally important". According to Landers, only 15-20 per cent of users of these skill-based gaming apps engage in monetary transactions; most stick to low-denomination games. "Serious losses are more often associated with illegal platforms," he adds.

Ravi Shankar Jha, director of public policy at Zupee, which offers RMGs like ludo and trump cards, believes regulation is key to addressing the issue. "The only way to address this imbalance is through regulations that separate legitimate skill gaming entities from illegal ones," he says. In the absence of clear recognition, Jha argues, users are unable to distinguish legal operators—who "promote responsible gaming"—from offshore betting and gambling sites.

Yet, the human toll of this epidemic is impossible to ignore. Many a time, the harmless-looking gaming apps become gateways to illegal betting apps—out of lack of awareness, financial need or sheer greed. On April 16, a 25-year-old MTech student in Hyderabad took his life after losing money in online betting, a grim reminder of the larger-than-life menace RMG is.

While the government's multi-pronged crackdown may rein in some abuses, enforcement remains a game of whack-a-mole. A Digital India Foundation report released on March 15 found that just four illegal betting platforms attracted a total of 1.6 billion visits in three months. Mirror sites, like those run by the Cyprus-headquartered sports betting giant PariMatch, alone contributed 266 million visits—dodging bans with ever-changing domains.

Without faster, smarter regulation, these platforms will keep thriving in the shadows. But the real battle isn't just shutting down rogue apps; it's changing the narrative—from addiction to awareness, from easy money to informed choice. Until then Surya Pratap, and millions like him, will remain prisoners of a costly addiction. ■